BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

CHAPTER 1
LANE FOURTEEN

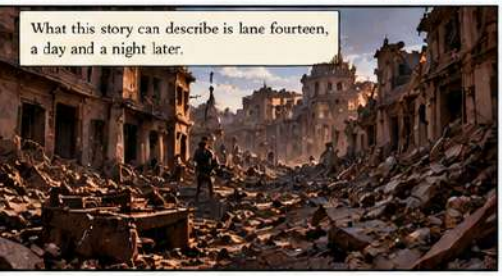
On the morning of the twenty-zisth of January, 2001, the old town of Bhuj was getting ready to raise the flag. Someone on lane fourteen was frying jalebis. Someone else was arguing with a radio.





At 8:46 the earth under Kutch moved for forty-five seconds, and a town that had stood for four hundred years did not.

It is not this story's job to describe those forty-five seconds. Twenty thousand people did not survive them, and they deserve better than adjectives.



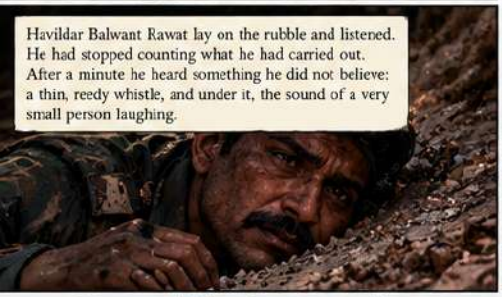
What this story can describe is lane fourteen, a day and a night later.



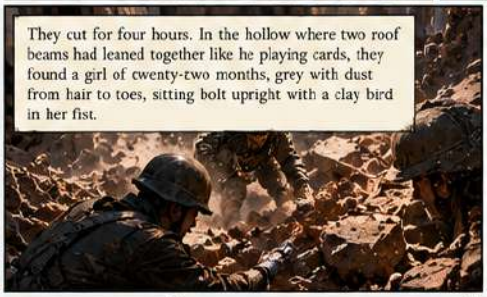
The Army engineers from the Bhuj cantonment had been working the old town with crowbars and bare hands since the first hour.



By the second morning they had cleared thirteen lanes and found nothing breathing on the fourteenth. A sniffer dog called Bruno, who had been right every time, sat down in front of a collapsed arch of beams and would not move.



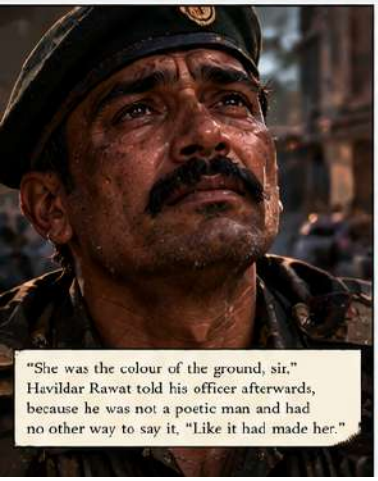
Havildar Balwant Rawat lay on the rubble and listened. He had stopped counting what he had carried out. After a minute he heard something he did not believe: a thin, reedy whistle, and under it, the sound of a very small person laughing.



They cut for four hours. In the hollow where two roof beams had leaned together like he playing cards, they found a girl of cwenty-two months, grey with dust from hair to toes, sitting bolt upright with a clay bird in her fist.



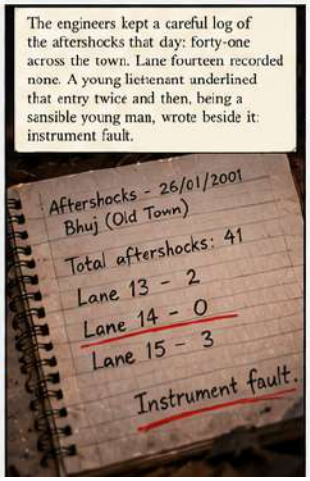
She blew the whistle at Havildar Rawat the moment his face appeared. Then she laughed again. She did not have a scratch on her.



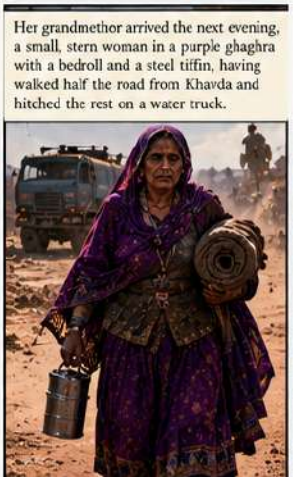
"She was the colour of the ground, sir," Havildar Rawat told his officer afterwards, because he was not a poetic man and had no other way to say it. "Like it had made her."



Her father Ramesh, a potter, and her mother Hansa did not survive, No one else on lane fourteen did.



The engineers kept a careful log of the aftershocks that day: forty-one across the town. Lane fourteen recorded none. A young lieticnant underlined that entry twice and then, being a sansible young man, wrote beside it: instrument fault.



Her grandmethor arrived the next evening, a small, stern woman in a purple ghaghra with a bedroll and a steel tiffin, having walked half the road from Khavda and hitched the rest on a water truck.



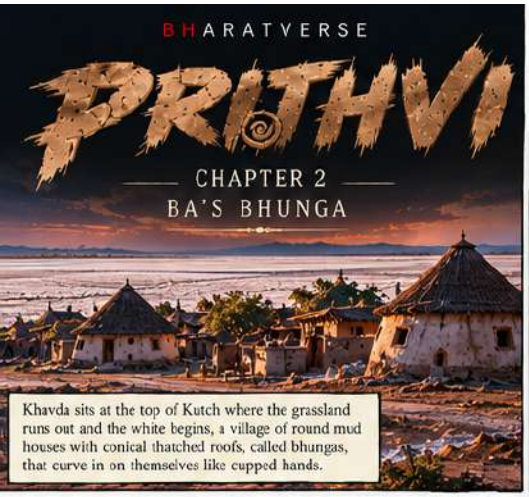
"The ground gave her back," said Jashoda Ba. "I will not insult it by losing her again."

She took the child home. She let the name stay. It seemed only polite.

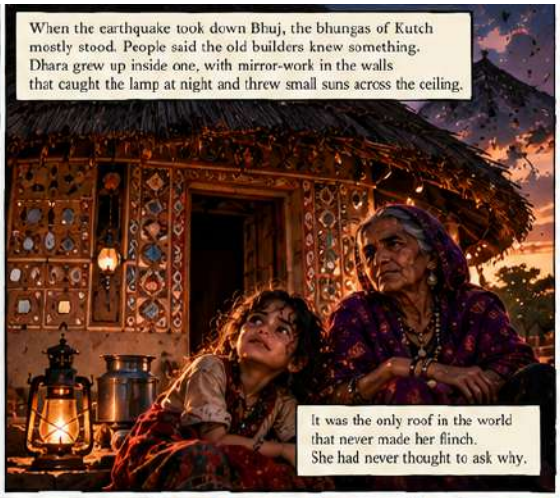
BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

CHAPTER 2
BA'S BHUNGA

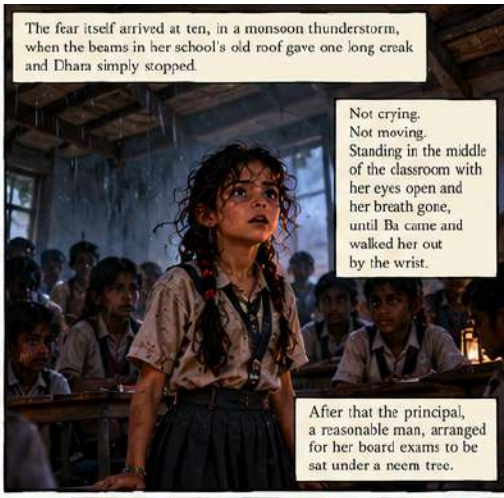


Khavda sits at the top of Kutch where the grassland runs out and the white begins, a village of round mud houses with conical thatched roofs, called bhungas, that curve in on themselves like cupped hands.



When the earthquake took down Bhuj, the bhungas of Kutch mostly stood. People said the old builders knew something. Dhara grew up inside one, with mirror-work in the walls that caught the lamp at night and threw small suns across the ceiling.

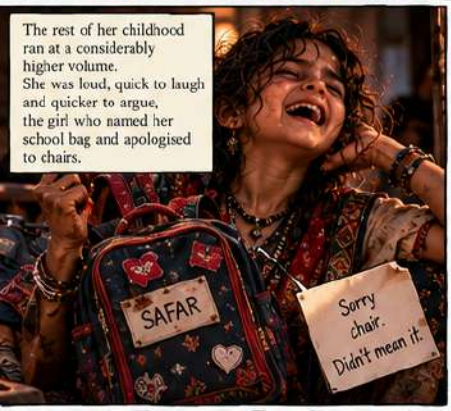
It was the only roof in the world that never made her flinch. She had never thought to ask why.



The fear itself arrived at ten, in a monsoon thunderstorm, when the beams in her school's old roof gave one long creak and Dhara simply stopped.

Not crying. Not moving. Standing in the middle of the classroom with her eyes open and her breath gone, until Ba came and walked her out by the wrist.

After that the principal, a reasonable man, arranged for her board exams to be sat under a neem tree.



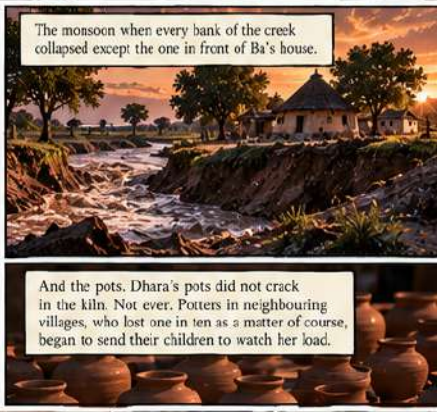
The rest of her childhood ran at a considerably higher volume. She was loud, quick to laugh and quicker to argue, the girl who named her school bag and apologised to chairs.



The village kept a running tally of small mysteries and, with the efficiency of village committees, filed them all as "Dhara things." The kabaddi match where the whole opposing team failed to drag her three feet.

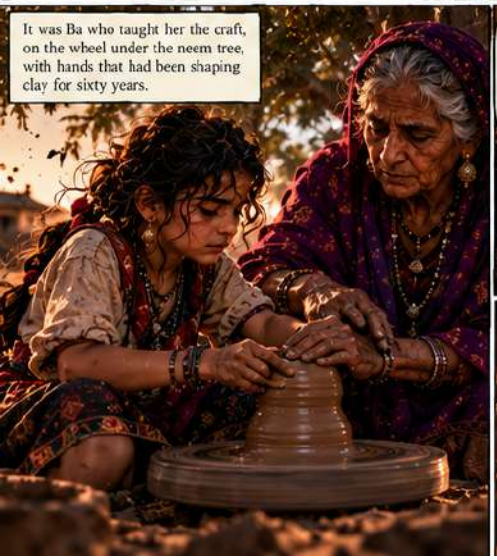


The tractor that refused to start when she sat on it, nervous, on the way to a wedding.

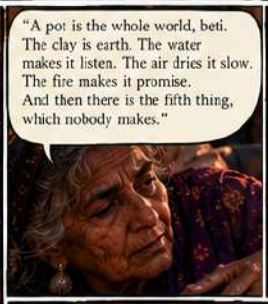


The monsoon when every bank of the creek collapsed except the one in front of Ba's house.

And the pots. Dhara's pots did not crack in the kiln. Not ever. Potters in neighbouring villages, who lost one in ten as a matter of course, began to send their children to watch her load.



It was Ba who taught her the craft, on the wheel under the neem tree, with hands that had been shaping clay for sixty years.



"A pot is the whole world, beti. The clay is earth. The water makes it listen. The air dries it slow. The fire makes it promise. And then there is the fifth thing, which nobody makes."



"What fifth thing?"



"The hollow." Ba tapped the empty inside of the pot. "It is mostly nothing, Mitti. That is why it can hold anything."



"That's the dumbest thing I've ever heard, Ba."

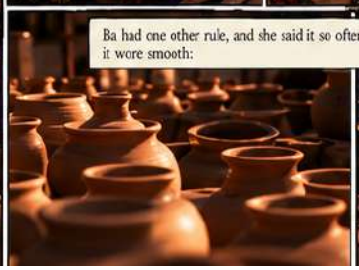


"You'll understand when you're older."



"I'm eight."

"Then you'll understand when you're nine."



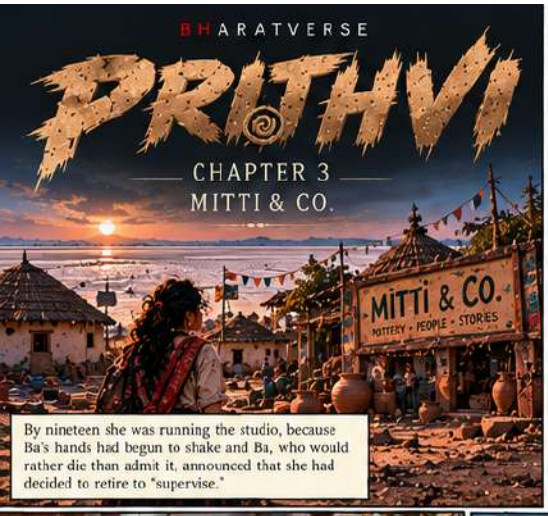
Ba had one other rule, and she said it so often it wore smooth:



"Never hurry the dry. Clay cracks when you rush it. Let it come back in its own time."



Dhara nodded and took none of it in. She would take all of it in later.



By nineteen she was running the studio, because Ba's hands had begun to shake and Ba, who would rather die than admit it, announced that she had decided to retire to "supervise."

Mehul Soni ran the mobile phone repair shop next door and had been her best friend since they were six and he had eaten a handful of kiln clay on a dare. He was thin, anxious, and incapable of seeing anything without wanting to film it. Within a year he had turned Mitti & Co. into a small internet sensation.

Dhara painted the sign herself in bright ochre and green. MITTI & CO., it said, in letters Mehul declared looked like a start-up from 1987.

Dhara and the Pots had forty-one thousand followers, and the most-shared reel in its history was titled *Pot of the Day #212: This Pot Is Disappointed In You.*

Dhara and the Pots
@mittiandco
41K Followers
312 Posts
1.2M Likes
Pot of the Day #212
This Pot Is Disappointed In You
▶ 2.4M

From December to February, when the Rann Utsav filled the white desert with tents and tourists, foreigners paid six hundred rupees to make a wobbly bowl while Dhara supervised with the patience of a saint and the commentary of a wrestling announcer.

MITTI & CO.
POTTERY EXPERIENCE WAIVER
I accept that the pot will outlive me.

She hauled her clay from the creek bank in a truck called *Basanti*, a battered Eicher painted from bumper to tailgate with peacocks, marigolds, a Taj Mahal done entirely from memory, and the slogan *Buri Nazar Waale Tera Muh Kaala*.

Buri Nazar Waale
Tera Muh Kaala
BASANTI

She drove with all four windows open and the radio loud, singing the wrong words to the right songs.

The BSF outpost two kilometres up the road sent one of its jawans, Sandeep Yadav, to the studio every evening, ostensibly on a routine security check. He stayed for Ba's chai, which was the strongest legal substance in the district, and left having learned nothing about security.

Ba's chai.
The strongest legal substance in the district.

The creek behind the village was called Chor Khadi, the thieves' creek, because years ago boats with no lights had come in along it at night and nobody had asked what they carried.

People had stopped asking. By Dhara's day the boats had stopped coming, and the creek was just a good place for clay and a bad place for swimming.

She had small, odd knacks she never remarked on. She always knew who was coming up the lane before they knocked.

She could tell, from the weight and rhythm of a tourist's stride, which of them was lying about being fine, and she would slide a cup of chai into their hands without a word. People said Dhara had a way with them.

The ground always told her first.

It was, by any honest measure, a good life: loud, colourful, and entirely above ground.

MITTI & CO.
POTTERY
PEOPLE
STORIES

She would have told you she wanted for nothing. Underneath her, very patiently, something disagreed.

BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

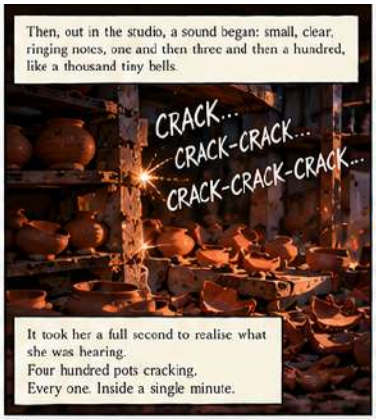
CHAPTER 4
EVERY POT CRACKED



It happened at 2:07 on a Tuesday morning, nine days before the start of the Rann Utsav, with four hundred pots in the kiln.



She woke before she knew why. The room was quiet. The air had a pressure to it, like the moment before a sneeze.

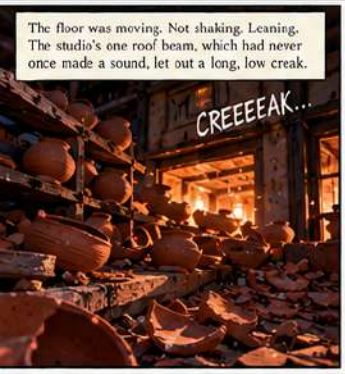


Then, out in the studio, a sound began: small, clear, ringing notes, one and then three and then a hundred, like a thousand tiny bells.

It took her a full second to realise what she was hearing.
Four hundred pots cracking.
Every one. Inside a single minute.



She ran in barefoot. The kiln stood open, its shelves lined with orange-red ware, and every piece had a fine bright seam running through it, as if someone had drawn a pencil line down each.



The floor was moving. Not shaking. Leaning. The studio's one roof beam, which had never once made a sound, let out a long, low creak.



Dhara stopped.
She stood in the middle of the floor with her mouth open and no air in her body, exactly as she had stood at ten. She could hear the creak. She could not hear anything else.
The ground leaned again.





She did not know why she obeyed.
She dropped to her knees and pressed both palms flat against the packed-earth floor.



Something under her hands was enormous. It was awake. It had been asleep for longer than there had been a Rann, or a Kutch, or a people to name it, and it had turned over in the dark like a whale beneath a boat. It was the size of a province. It was frightened.
It was a great slow creature woken suddenly by something it could not see, and it was thrashing the only way it knew how.

Dhara said the thing she had said to frightened buffaloes since she was six.
"Shhh. Shhh. It's all right. It's all right. I'm here."

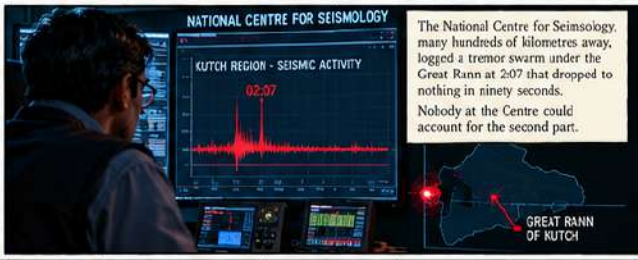


And the ground listened.

The leaning eased.
The creak stopped.



Out across the village, a thousand dogs began barking at once into a silence so sudden it rang.



The National Centre for Seismology, many hundreds of kilometres away, logged a tremor swarm under the Great Rann at 2:07 that dropped to nothing in ninety seconds.
Nobody at the Centre could account for the second part.



At dawn Dhara and Ba sat on the studio step and swept up four hundred broken pots.



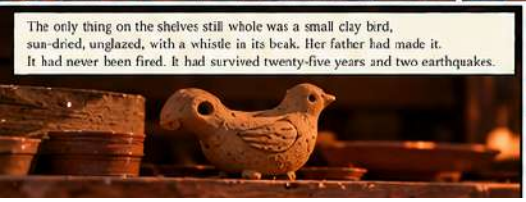








She had not said a word yet, so it was impossible that he could see it. But she did have that look.



The only thing on the shelves still whole was a small clay bird, sun-dried, unglazed, with a whistle in its beak. Her father had made it. It had never been fired. It had survived twenty-five years and two earthquakes.



Ba picked it up, turned it over, and set it back on its shelf.



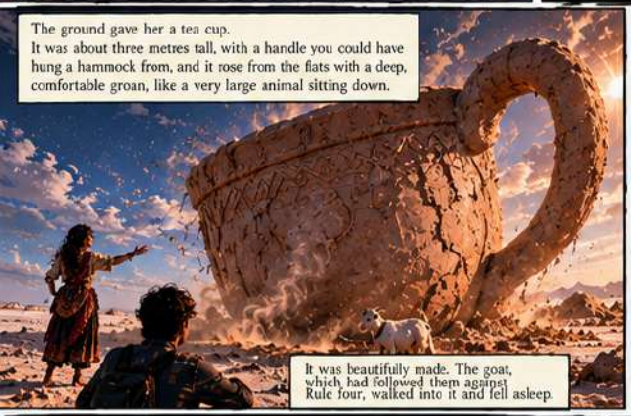




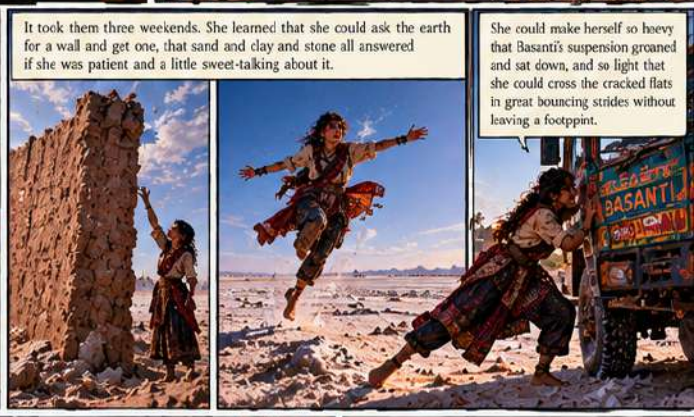

BHARATVERSE
PRITHVI
CHAPTER 5
THE TEA CUP
BASANTI
"Okay, rules," said Mehul. He had drawn them on a whiteboard in his shop with the confidence of a man who had no idea what he was doing.


"Rule one: we do not film this. Rule two: if anything weird happens, you stop. Rule three: nobody tells Ba.
RULES
1. We do not film this.
2. If anything weird happens, you stop.
3. Nobody tells Ba.
4. No giant anything near the goat.
"Ba already knows."
"Of course she does. Rule four: no giant anything near the goat."

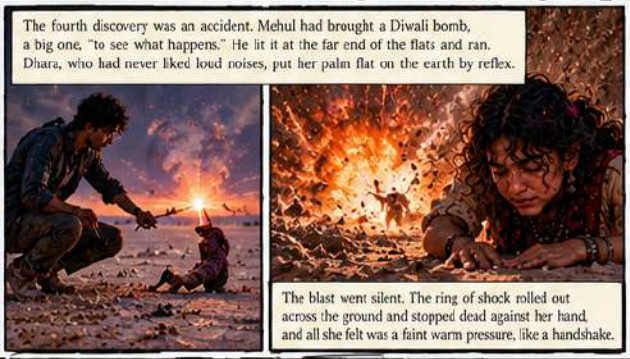

It was a Sunday, and they were out on the baked flats behind the creek where nobody ever came.
Dhara stood with her bare feet on the clay and her hands out, the way Mehul had once seen a magician do it in a film. She felt ridiculous. She asked the ground, politely, for a cup of tea.


The ground gave her a tea cup.
It was about three metres tall, with a handle you could have hung a hammock from, and it rose from the flats with a deep, comfortable groan, like a very large animal sitting down.
It was beautifully made. The goat, which had followed them against Rule four, walked into it and fell asleep.


"Rule four," Mehul said faintly.
"I was aiming small!"


It took them three weekends. She learned that she could ask the earth for a wall and get one, that sand and clay and stone all answered if she was patient and a little sweet-talking about it.
She could make herself so heavy that Basanti's suspension groaned and sat down, and so light that she could cross the cracked flats in great bouncing strides without leaving a footprint.
BASANTI


She learned that the ground carried gossip. She could feel Mehul's heartbeat from fifty paces, and Ba humming in the kitchen, and Sandeep Yadav pacing the outpost two kilometres away, bored, composing a text message he would never send.


The fourth discovery was an accident. Mehul had brought a Diwali bomb, a big one, "to see what happens." He lit it at the far end of the flats and ran. Dhara, who had never liked loud noises, put her palm flat on the earth by reflex.
The blast went silent. The ring of shock rolled out across the ground and stopped dead against her hand, and all she felt was a faint warm pressure, like a handshake.


She stared at her palm. Mehul stared at her.
"That," he said, "was the most useful thing I have ever seen, and I am so scared I'm not even going to film it."
It was the first time she understood that the thing under her feet was not only strong. It was gentle. It could take the shaking out of the world, if she asked.


"We need a name for you," Mehul said that evening, on the step with the chai.


"I'm not doing a name."
"Everyone has a name."


"Mitti's too cute, Dharti sounds like a TV serial. Bhoomi sounds like a bank."
"What does that leave?"


He thought. "Prithvi?"


She tried it out loud. It was a respectable name. It was the kind of name you could say to a police officer.
"Fine," said Dhara.


"But the goat gets a name too."

BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

CHAPTER 6
CURING



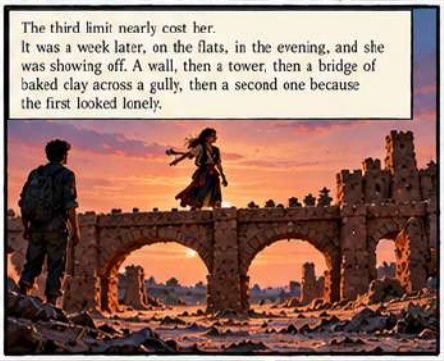
She found the limits the way everyone finds limits: by running into them at speed.











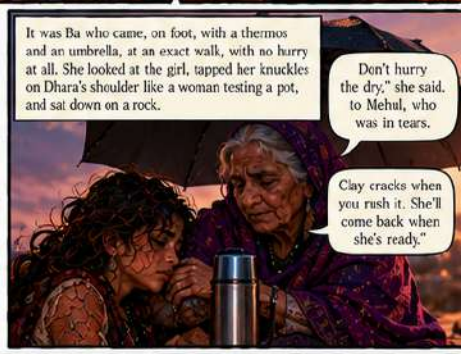








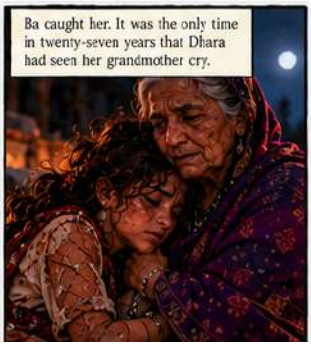










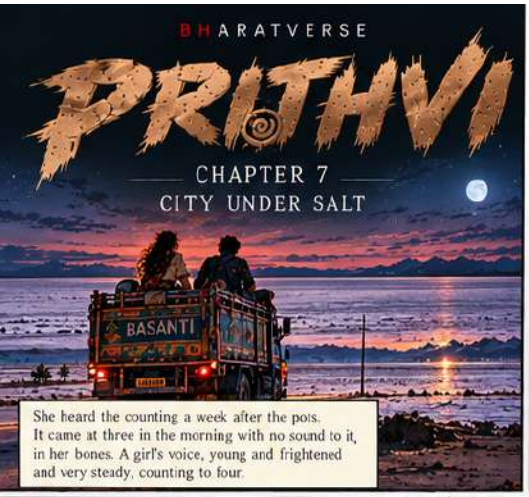




BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

CHAPTER 7
CITY UNDER SALT



She heard the counting a week after the pots.
It came at three in the morning with no sound to it, in her bones. A girl's voice, young and frightened and very steady, counting to four.

One. Two. Three.
There was a terror under the numbers like a drowning person's. And then, on four, a stillness spread out across the ground like water finding its level, and the terror let go, far away, in some place she could not see.



Dhara sat up in the dark with her hands pressed flat to the floor.

Under it was a chord. Five notes, a long way apart, held in the earth like strings in an instrument.



"There are other people," she told Ba at breakfast.
"I know." Ba did not look up from the stove.
"There's a girl. She's scared. I think someone's hurting her."
"Then someone needs you," said Ba. "Eat first."

The note was loudest out in the white, to the east, where the Rann ran toward the border, so at midnight she loaded Basanti with two flasks, a torch, and Mehul, who had been persuaded by the argument that the alternative was her going alone.



The road to Dholavira needed a border permit. They had none. They had Sandeep Yadav, who looked at the truck, and at Mehul, and at Dhara's face, and waved them through with the air of a man delivering chai.



Dholavira lies at the edge of the Rann like a city that has simply stopped talking: terraces of cut stone, great stepped reservoirs, wide streets laid out in a grid five thousand years before anyone in Europe thought of grids. There is a gate there with ten large signs above it that no one alive can read.



She could not read them either.
But she knew them, the way you know your own handwriting in a stranger's book.



She walked into the oldest part of the city, down a stone stair, into the dark of a reservoir that had been empty for forty centuries. She knelt and pressed her palms of the floor.



The ground did not speak. But it remembered, and it let her remember with it.
She was twenty-two months old. It was dark and loud and the world was ending.
And something vast and patient (the very, very old that cupped itself around the one small warm thing left alive on lane fourteen.
It had held her like two hands. It had taken the shaking out of the air for twenty-eight hours. It had not let go.



She wept on the stone for long time.
Mehul sat beside her, and, for once, said nothing.

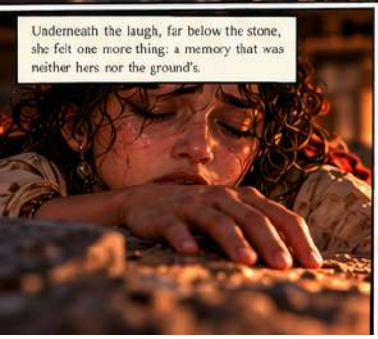


"I'm going to say something and you can't be mad.
This is the best content I have ever not filmed."



She laughed, wetly.
It was the right thing to do.

Underneath the laugh, far below the stone, she felt one more thing: a memory that was neither hers nor the ground's.



A hard, thin tap from aftar away, twenty-five years ago, like a hammer on a bell.



Something had woken the ground that day.
Something had struck it.



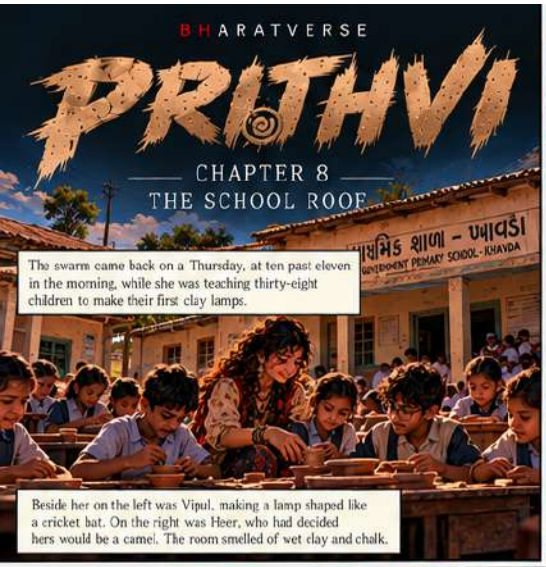
She did not know what.
She filed it, the way you file a crack in a wall you plan to come back to.



BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI

CHAPTER 8
THE SCHOOL ROOF



The swarm came back on a Thursday, at ten past eleven in the morning, while she was teaching thirty-eight children to make their first clay lamps.

Beside her on the left was Vipul, making a lamp shaped like a cricket bat. On the right was Heer, who had decided hers would be a camel. The room smelled of wet clay and chalk.



The first tremor was small. A shiver in the floor, a rattle in the windows.



Then the beams over the room gave one slow, groaning creak.



She stopped. It was the same sound. The same beams, the same sky of iron and tin above a room full of small children.



"Didi," said Heer, looking up from her camel. She tugged Dhara's sleeve.

She put a hand to her cheek and found it wet.

She thought of the arch on lane fourteen. She thought of something vast and patient cupping itself around her for twenty-eight hours.

It held me. I can hold them.



She dropped to her knees, put both palms flat to the floor, and said in a very clear voice,

"Everybody out. Walk. Don't run. Walk."



The children went in a line, quitely, the way they did in fire drills, and she let them.

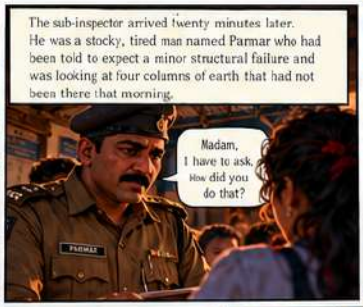


Four columns of packed earth rose through the floor, and braced the beams, thick and sure, and she held them.

She took every shake in the ground and let it go quiet, and se held the roof ofthe school above the empty room until the last child was out and the last tremor had died.

It took four minutes.

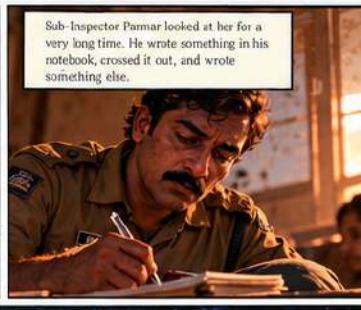
When she walked out, her knees were shaking and her fingers were beginning, faintly, to stiffen. She sat down hard of the step, and Mehul, who nad come running, put a hand on her back and said nothing at all.



The sub-inspector arrived twenty minutes later. He was a stocky, tired man named Parmar who had been told to expect a minor structural failure and was looking at four columns of earth that had not been there that morning.



Dhara looked at him. She looked at the thirty-eight children in the yard, all alive. She looked at her own hands, ochre to the wrists.



Sub-Inspector Parmar looked at her for a very long time. He wrote something in his notebook, crossed it out, and wrote something else.



Later, on Basanti's flatbed, with Ba's chai in her hands and the feeling coming back to her fingers, Mehul said, very quietly,

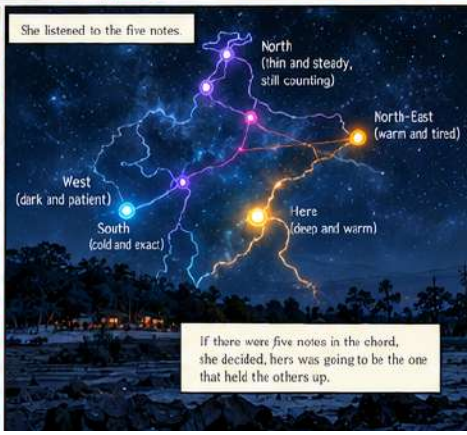


At the end of the lane, a grey government jeep with a tripod on its roof sat idling. Nobody got out. After a minute it drove away.



That night Ishge lay the bhunga with the mirror-work throwing small suns across the ceiling, and it occurred to her for the first time that there were no beams in it. No iron. No weight hanging over her head to creak. It was only a round of mud and thatch, built by people who had understood something about holding.

She had never asked why she felt safe there. It was that simple.



She listened to the five notes.

If there were five notes in the chord, she decided, hers was going to be the one that held the others up.